



Embroided in controversy: Five-time world champion Magnus Carlsen alleged that Indian prodigy Nihal Sarin made "several illegal moves" against Carlsen's teammate Daniel Dardha in the Global Chess League. However, the tournament's appeals committee ruled that the draw result will stand. GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

P. K. Ajith Kumar

ajithkumar.pk@thehindu.co.in

At Friends House in central London on an overcast October afternoon, there is a large number of children, some with their chessboards, others with autograph books. There is no prize for guessing which player they are most eager to meet.

Magnus Carlsen has undoubtedly been the Virat Kohli of chess for over a decade. The World No.1 from Norway headlined a stellar cast for Season 2 of the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League, which moved to London after the inaugural edition in Dubai.

The world's first franchise-based chess league, a joint venture between FIDE and Tech Mahindra,

got bigger this time with the addition of two of the biggest names in world chess — World No. 2 Hikaru Nakamura and Alireza Firouzja, who Carlsen has described as the world's finest among young talents.

Another major attraction was the presence of seven of the 10 members of the history-making Indian contingent at the Chess Olympiad, which had ended a week earlier in Budapest. Arjun Erigaisi, R. Praggnanandhaa, Vidit Gujrathi, Dronavalli Harika, and R. Vaishali all

played, while Tania Sachdev was a commentator, and Vantika Agrawal was a brand ambassador for the league and also doubled up as a reserve player.

Interestingly, the champion side had no Indian presence. Triveni Continental Kings, which retained the title after beating PBG Alaskan Knights in the final, was well served by Firouzja, who was a last-minute replacement for the Russian Ian Nepomniachtchi. He was in top form on the Icon board as he took on the

« The world's first franchise-based chess league expanded with the addition of two major stars — Hikaru Nakamura and Alireza Firouzja »